



Olmec stone mask

Olmec civilization
1500–400 BCE
The first major culture in Central America, the Olmecs lived in what is now Mexico. They were expert farmers and traded all over the region. They developed one of the first writing systems in the Americas.



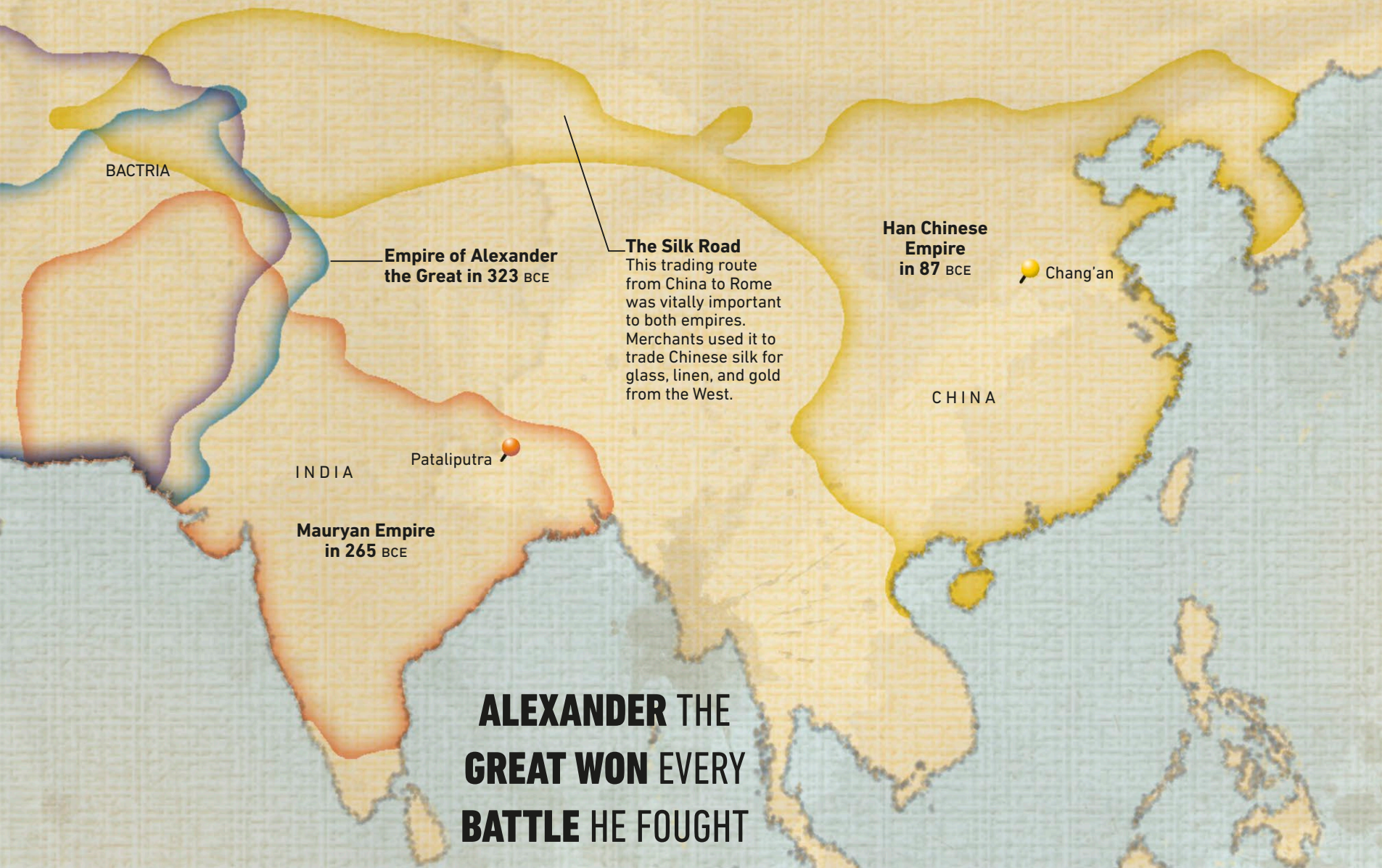
Ornate Persian silver bowl

First Persian Empire
550–336 BCE
Cyrus the Great and his army conquered huge swathes of central Asia and grabbed enormous wealth from the kingdoms they conquered. Cyrus's successor, Darius I, built cities, roads, and even a canal from the Nile river to the Red Sea.



Coin showing Alexander the Great's head

Empire of Alexander the Great
330–323 BCE
Alexander was a general from Macedon, a kingdom north of Greece. At its height, his empire covered most of the world known to Greeks. For centuries after his death, the Greek culture that he introduced continued to dominate the eastern Mediterranean and western Asia.



Mauryan Empire
321–185 BCE
Chandragupta Maurya was the first leader to conquer the entire Indian subcontinent. His son Ashoka became a Buddhist and ruled the empire peacefully for 42 years.

Mauryan figure



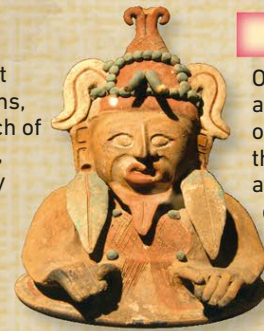
Han pot

Han Empire
206–220 CE
The four centuries of Han rule are often called the Golden Age of Ancient China. It was an era of peace and prosperity in which China became a major world power.



Head of Emperor Claudius

Roman Empire
27 BCE–476 CE
One of history's most influential civilizations, Rome controlled much of Europe, western Asia, and north Africa. Many roads, aqueducts, and canals built by the Romans are still in use today.



Mayan statuette

Mayan civilization
500–900 CE
One of the most advanced cultures of the ancient world, the Maya developed an accurate yearly calendar based on their sophisticated understanding of astronomy.